

expectations,” in which observers are shown to rationally converge on the same inference when supplied with the same data, even if their initial hypotheses were markedly different (by a mechanism of updating called Bayesian inference). Why unrigorous? Because one needs a very quick check to see that people do not converge to the same opinions in reality. This is partly, as we saw in [Chapter 6](#), because of psychological distortions such as the confirmation bias, which cause divergent interpretation of the data. But there is a mathematical reason why people do not converge to the same opinion: if you are using a probability distribution from Extremistan, and I am using a distribution from Mediocristan (or a different one from Extremistan), then we will never converge, simply because if you suppose Extremistan you do not update (or change your mind) that quickly. For instance, if you assume Mediocristan and do not witness Black Swans, you may eventually rule them out. Not if you assume we are in Extremistan.

To conclude, assuming that “randomness” is not epistemic and subjective, or making a big deal about the distinction between “ontological randomness” and “epistemic randomness,” implies some scientific autism, that desire to systematize, and a fundamental lack of understanding of randomness itself. It assumes that an observer can reach omniscience and can compute odds with perfect realism and without violating consistency rules. What is left becomes “randomness,” or something by another name that arises from aleatory forces that cannot be reduced by knowledge and analysis.

There is an angle worth exploring: why on earth do adults accept these Soviet-Harvard-style top-down methods without laughing, and actually go to build policies in Washington based on them, against the record, except perhaps to make readers of history laugh at them and diagnose new psychiatric conditions? And, likewise, why do we default to the assumption that events are experienced by people in the same manner? Why did we ever take notions of “objective” probability seriously?

After this foray into the psychology of the perception of the dynamics of time and events, let us move to our central point, the very core of our program, into what I have aggressively called the most useful problem in philosophy. The most useful, sadly.

* Robert Merton, the villain of [Chapter 17](#), a person said to be of a highly mechanistic mind (down to his interest in machinery and his use of mechanical metaphors to represent uncertainty), seems to have been created for the sole purpose of providing an illustration of dangerous Black Swan foolishness. After the crisis of 2008, he defended the risk taking caused by economists, giving the argument that “it was a Black Swan” simply because he did not see it coming, therefore, he said, the theories were fine. He did not make the leap that, since we do not see these events coming, we need to be robust to them.